

MUS262: Modal Jazz Artists & Beyond

WithAI Research

March 2026

MUS262: Lecture Notes - Modal Jazz Artists & Beyond

Date: March 2026

Topic: Key Artists in Modal Jazz, Cool Jazz, and Transitional Periods

Required Reading Context

Chapter 3: "Chad's Compositions and Beagles from the Nation"

Key Points from Reading:

- **Page 66:** Jazz musicians learn pieces in all 12 keys
 - Bebop was the first style that emphasized practicing in all 12 keys
 - All different voicings of chords across keys
 - **Page 71:** Chord progressions = roadmap that musicians follow
 - **Page 72:** Many jazz tunes learned by ear
 - Western classical music combines ear training (harmony, melody, rhythm) with written scores
 - **Page 76: Learning the blues is the first thing jazz students learn**
 - Very simple structure: one scale, four chord progressions
 - Great way to begin improvising
 - **Page 85:** Chord substitutions enrich harmony
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I. Wayne Shorter (b. 1933 - d. 2023)

Background

- Born in New Jersey (1933)
- Died in his late 80s (2023)
- One of the most important composers and saxophonists in jazz history

Career Trajectory

1. **Early Career:** Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers (1960)
 - Initially sounded similar to young Coltrane
2. **Miles Davis Quintet (1960s)**
 - Resident composer for Miles' band
 - Wrote the lion's share of material recorded in the 1960s
 - Played with Herbie Hancock, Ron Carter, Tony Williams
3. **Later Career:** Co-founded **Weather Report** (1970s)
 - Important fusion group (jazz + rock)
 - Embraced fusion like Miles Davis

Musical Style

- Beautiful sensibility in harmony
- Very unique compositional approach

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- Different from Coltrane's approach

Key Album: *Speak No Evil* (1964)

Personnel:

- Wayne Shorter - tenor saxophone
- Freddie Hubbard - trumpet
- Herbie Hancock - piano
- Ron Carter - bass
- Elvin Jones - drums

Characteristics of "Speak No Evil" (title track):

- Modal jazz approach
- Emphasis on **single-note melodic lines**
- Heavy use of **rhythmic elements** vs. harmonic expansion
- Dramatic, tension-building lines
- Different from Coltrane's sheets of sound approach
- More focused on rhythm than layering harmonies

Recording Date: December 24, 1964

II. John Coltrane - *A Love Supreme* (1964)

Background on the Album

- Recorded December 9, 1964 (just 2 weeks before *Speak No Evil*)
- **Most famous work** for non-jazz audiences
- Four-movement suite expressing spiritual devotion

Spiritual Context

- Coltrane experienced spiritual awakening in 1957
- After overcoming addiction
- Album described as "musical praise to the Almighty"
- Associated with Cornel West (scholar who frequently references this album)

Musical Evolution

- Represents transition point in Coltrane's career
- Last modal jazz record before moving into **free jazz** (1965-67)
- Changed approach to soloing
- Moved away from bebop style of "Giant Steps"
- Developed fractured lines
- Increased use of vibrato
- **"Reaching" sound** in upper register
- Harder, thicker tone quality

"Acknowledgment" (First Movement)

Original Recording Personnel:

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- John Coltrane - tenor saxophone
 - McCoy Tyner - piano
 - Jimmy Garrison - bass
 - Elvin Jones - drums

Notable Feature: Coltrane's famous **chant** at the end

- "A Love Supreme" chanted repeatedly
- Overdubbed himself twice (two vocal tracks)
- Only master take includes the chanting
- Interesting choice to use only 2 voices (not 5 or 12)
- Creates sparse, reverent quality

Other Versions:

- Takes with **Archie Shepp** (tenor sax) and **Art Davis** (second bass) discovered 25 years later
- *A Love Supreme: Live in Seattle* (released recently)
- Features Pharaoh Sanders on tenor sax (joined group late 1965)

Comparison: Wayne Shorter vs. John Coltrane

- **Timbre similarities:** Both have harder, thicker tenor saxophone tone
 - **Soloing approach differences:**
 - Shorter: Single-note melodic lines, rhythmically focused
 - Coltrane: More expansive, "sheets of sound," reaching/screaming quality
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III. Dave Brubeck (1920-2012)

Background

- Born in San Francisco (1920)
- Died at age 91 (2012)
- Long career - performed live into old age
- Associated with **West Coast cool jazz** scene

Historical Controversy: Time Magazine Cover (1954)

- First time Time Magazine did cover story on jazz
- **Dave Brubeck was chosen** for the cover
- Major controversy: Brubeck was white
- Miles Davis, Duke Ellington, Louis Armstrong were all active but never featured
- Brubeck expressed embarrassment about this
- Acknowledged more deserving Black musicians around him
- Understood he was chosen because he was white
- Reveals racial dynamics of 1954 (early Civil Rights era)

The Dave Brubeck Quartet (1951)

Key Members:

- Dave Brubeck - piano

- **Paul Desmond** - alto saxophone
- Eugene Wright - bass
- Joe Morello - drums

Time Out Album & "Take Five" (1959)

Significance:

- Same year as *Kind of Blue*
- Year before Coltrane's *My Favorite Things*
- One of the most iconic jazz pieces ever recorded

Musical Innovation: 5/4 Time Signature

- Title "Take Five" refers to the time signature
- Unusual for the era (most jazz in 4/4 or 3/4)
- Memorable melody

Structure:

- Modal piece (vamp on one chord)
- Bridge has some chord changes
- Composed by **Paul Desmond** (not Brubeck)

Characteristics:

- **Cool jazz sound:** lighter tone, less vibrato, laid back
- Different from Charlie Parker's bebop alto sound
- Persistent, intense bass line throughout (similar devotion as Steve Davis on "My Favorite Things")
- Mixture of sections with varying energy
- Laid-back sections
- More intense middle sections
- Returns to laid-back feel

Accessibility:

- More commercializable/accessible than some other jazz
- Contained, not overly complex
- Appeals to average listeners
- Memorable melody

Paul Desmond's Alto Saxophone Sound

- Cool jazz approach
- Lighter tone with less vibrato
- More laid-back delivery
- Contrast to bebop intensity

IV. Stan Getz (1927-1991) & Bossa Nova

Background

- Born in Philadelphia (1927)

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- Died in California (1991) at age 64
 - Moved to New York in late 1930s
 - Sound derived from **Lester Young** (cool jazz lineage)
 - Could also play bebop despite cool sound

Bossa Nova Craze (1960s)

- **Bossa nova** = Brazilian samba + American jazz
- Huge cultural phenomenon
- Bridge between Brazil and America

Key Figures:

- **João Gilberto** and **Antonio Carlos Jobim** from Brazil
- Stan Getz in United States
- Many hard bop musicians also recorded bossa nova albums (e.g., Kenny Dorham)

"The Girl from Ipanema" (Getz/Gilberto, 1964)

Personnel:

- Stan Getz - tenor saxophone
- João Gilberto - guitar/vocals
- **Astrud Gilberto** - vocals
- Antonio Carlos Jobim - piano

Characteristics:

- Extremely laid back, "nonchalant"
- **Breathy saxophone tone** - hallmark of cool jazz
- Not pushing the sound
- Instruments held back, restrained
- Creates ambiance and mood

Astrud Gilberto's Vocal Style:

- Not as virtuosic as Ella Fitzgerald
- Breathy, understated approach
- Added to the cool jazz aesthetic
- "Not as hot" - deliberately cooler temperature

Cultural Impact:

- Won Grammy Award
- One of the most iconic jazz standards
- Played at Olympics when held in Brazil (Gisele Bündchen walked to it in opening ceremony)
- Became synonymous with Brazilian culture globally

Cool Jazz vs. Bebop:

- Cool = breathy, laid back, lighter tone
- Bebop = intense, virtuosic, harder tone

V. Andrew Hill (1931-2007) - Transitional Figure

Background

- Born in Chicago (1931)
- Died 2007 at age 75
- Moved to NYC in 1961
- Signed to **Blue Note Records** (1963)
- Major label for jazz greats

Musical Identity

- **Unique, individual sound** (like Thelonious Monk)
- Didn't sound like anyone else
- If compared to anyone: closest to **Thelonious Monk**
- Did not achieve popularity of contemporaries
- But highly respected as composer

Point of Departure (1964)

Album Significance:

- Title reflects what's coming: **pushing boundaries of modal jazz**
- Still modal jazz but **moving toward free jazz**
- Transitional recording

"Refuge" (Opening Track) - Personnel:

- Andrew Hill - piano
- **Kenny Dorham** - trumpet (played with Charlie Parker)
- **Joe Henderson** - tenor saxophone
- **Eric Dolphy** - alto saxophone and other instruments (free jazz pioneer)
- Richard Davis - bass
- **Tony Williams** - drums (Miles Davis drummer at the time)

Musical Characteristics:

- Very **dense texture**
- **Angular and dissonant**
- Influences from **impressionist music**
- Blend of jazz and impressionism
- Still has structure underneath the complexity
- Piano interludes return after each wind solo
- Wind instruments come in with harmonic melody after rhythm section
- Pattern/form exists despite dissonance

Listener Reactions:

- Challenging, doesn't immediately "make sense"
- Requires multiple listens
- More complex than accessible pieces like "Take Five" or "Girl from Ipanema"
- Shows direction jazz is heading: freer, more experimental

Key Comparisons & Study Points

Modal Jazz Evolution Timeline

1. **1959:** *Kind of Blue* (Miles Davis) - establishes modal jazz
2. **1959:** *Time Out* (Brubeck) - modal jazz in cool style
3. **1960:** *My Favorite Things* (Coltrane) - modal jazz with Eastern influences
4. **1964:** *Speak No Evil* (Wayne Shorter) - modal jazz with rhythmic focus
5. **1964:** *A Love Supreme* (Coltrane) - modal jazz moving toward free jazz
6. **1964:** *Point of Departure* (Andrew Hill) - modal jazz pushing boundaries
7. **1965-67:** Coltrane enters **free jazz** period

Stylistic Comparisons

Artist	Sound Characteristics	Approach to Soloing
Wayne Shorter	Hard, thick tenor tone	Single-note melodic lines, rhythmically focused
John Coltrane	Hard, thick tenor tone with vibrato; "reaching" quality	Sheets of sound, harmonic expansion, spiritual intensity
Paul Desmond	Light, breathy alto tone	Cool, laid-back, melodic
Stan Getz	Light, breathy tenor tone	Cool, restrained, melodic

Cool Jazz vs. Hard Bop/Modal Jazz

Cool Jazz:

- Lighter tone quality
- More breathy sound
- Laid-back feel
- Less vibrato
- West Coast association
- More accessible to general audiences

Hard Bop/Modal Jazz:

- Harder, thicker tone
- More intense delivery
- Can be more aggressive
- More complex harmonically
- East Coast association

Timbre Vocabulary

- **Breathy:** Airy quality to the sound
- **Hard/Thick tone:** Dense, solid sound quality
- **Vibrato:** Oscillation in pitch (Coltrane used more; cool jazz used less)

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- **Reaching quality:** Straining toward upper register (Coltrane's later style)
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Important Concepts to Remember

1. **All 12 Keys:** Bebop era established practice of learning tunes in all keys
 2. **Blues as Foundation:** First thing jazz students learn due to simple structure
 3. **Modal Jazz = Chord Vamp:** Staying on one or two chords for extended periods
 4. **Chord Substitution:** Technique to enrich harmony
 5. **Time Signatures:** "Take Five" = 5/4 time (unusual for era)
 6. **Learning by Ear:** Many jazz standards learned without sheet music
 7. **Spiritual Dimension:** *A Love Supreme* represents jazz as spiritual expression
 8. **Cultural Exchange:** Bossa nova as fusion of Brazilian and American music
 9. **Racial Dynamics in Jazz History:** Time Magazine controversy (1954)
 10. **Evolution Toward Free Jazz:** Modal jazz as stepping stone to more experimental forms
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Study Questions

1. How does Wayne Shorter's approach to improvisation differ from John Coltrane's?
 2. What makes "Take Five" structurally unusual for its time?
 3. Why was Dave Brubeck's Time Magazine cover controversial in 1954?
 4. Describe the characteristics of "cool jazz" sound and name two key artists.
 5. What is bossa nova and how did it influence American jazz?
 6. How does *A Love Supreme* represent a transition point in Coltrane's career?
 7. What role did the blues play in jazz education?
 8. How does Andrew Hill's "Refuge" push the boundaries of modal jazz?
 9. Compare the saxophone sounds of Paul Desmond, Stan Getz, Wayne Shorter, and John Coltrane.
 10. What is the significance of learning tunes in all 12 keys?
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Musicians to Know (with their associated albums)

Saxophonists:

- **Wayne Shorter** - *Speak No Evil* (1964)
- **John Coltrane** - *A Love Supreme* (1964)
- **Paul Desmond** - *Time Out* (1959) with Dave Brubeck
- **Stan Getz** - *Getz/Gilberto* (1964)
- **Joe Henderson** - *Point of Departure* (1964)
- **Eric Dolphy** - *Point of Departure* (1964)

Pianists:

- **Dave Brubeck** - *Time Out* (1959)
- **Herbie Hancock** - *Speak No Evil* (1964)

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- **McCoy Tyner** - *A Love Supreme* (1964)
 - **Andrew Hill** - *Point of Departure* (1964)

Drummers:

- **Elvin Jones** - *Speak No Evil* & *A Love Supreme* (1964)
- **Joe Morello** - *Time Out* (1959)
- **Tony Williams** - *Point of Departure* (1964)

Bassists:

- **Ron Carter** - *Speak No Evil* (1964)
- **Jimmy Garrison** - *A Love Supreme* (1964)
- **Richard Davis** - *Point of Departure* (1964)

Trumpeters:

- **Freddie Hubbard** - *Speak No Evil* (1964)
- **Kenny Dorham** - *Point of Departure* (1964)

Listening Assignments Review

Make sure you can identify and discuss:

1. **"Speak No Evil"** - Wayne Shorter (1964)
2. **"Acknowledgment"** from *A Love Supreme* - John Coltrane (1964)
3. **"Take Five"** - Dave Brubeck Quartet (1959)
4. **"The Girl from Ipanema"** - Stan Getz/João Gilberto (1964)
5. **"Refuge"** - Andrew Hill (1964)

Additional Resources Mentioned

- **Ken Burns' Jazz Documentary Series** (10 parts) - features interview with Dave Brubeck
- **Cornel West** - scholar who frequently references *A Love Supreme*
- **Alternate takes** of *A Love Supreme* with Archie Shepp and Art Davis
- **Weather Report** - Wayne Shorter's fusion group (1970s)

Timeline Reference

1950s:

- 1954: Time Magazine Dave Brubeck cover controversy
- 1957: Coltrane's spiritual awakening
- 1959: *Kind of Blue*, *Time Out*, modal jazz established

1960s:

- 1960: Wayne Shorter joins Art Blakey; *My Favorite Things* (Coltrane)
- 1961: Andrew Hill moves to NYC

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- 1963: Andrew Hill signs to Blue Note Records
 - 1964: **Banner year** - *Speak No Evil*, *A Love Supreme*, *Getz/Gilberto*, *Point of Departure*
 - 1965-67: Coltrane's free jazz period

1970s:

- Weather Report founded (Wayne Shorter)

End of Lecture Notes